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Pre-AP English 10

Frankenstein Essay

The Effect of Isolation on the Perception of Nature in *Frankenstein*

In early 2022, the World Health Organization reported that the COVID-19 pandemic triggered a 25% increase in the prevalence of anxiety and depression worldwide. Despite being necessary for ensuring safety, mandatory quarantines enforced isolation of people from their friends, family, and community, causing a widespread drop in overall happiness and mental health through this significant lack of social interaction. One may draw parallels between their experiences in isolation with that of Mary Shelley's story of Victor Frankenstein's life. In Mary Shelley's gothic fiction novel *Frankenstein*, Shelley provides a cautionary depiction of the potential impacts of isolation on mental health and mood. The novel follows the journey of a man whose scientific passion manifests into obsession, as he falls into depression by constantly isolating himself from the world and his loved ones. Victor Frankenstein's perceptions of the beauty of nature reveal not only the harmful effects of isolation but also the benefits of being surrounded by loved ones.

Frankenstein's acknowledgment of the beauty of nature around him reflects his inner well-being and helps emphasize his happiness and positive thoughts when he is with his friends and family. In the first volume, Victor's creation kills his younger brother, and an innocent girl dies after being falsely accused of murder. At the beginning of the second volume, Victor expresses his immense guilt as he knows he was indeed responsible for the creature's crime but instead lets an innocent girl die. He states how he "shunned the face of man; all sound of joy or

complacency was torture to me; solitude was my only consolation - deep, dark, death-like solitude” (Shelley 65). Victor isolates himself and clouds himself with negative thoughts, claiming to only be truly consoled by his solitude. However, he contradicts himself later when he is with his family around nature. He describes that “[the] sublime and magnificent scenes afforded me the greatest consolation that I was capable of receiving” (Shelley 69). Frankenstein opposes his earlier claim as he finds better, more sincere consolation in nature’s beauty. This change in mood occurs when Frankenstein is with his family after his long period of isolation and sorrow, suggesting a correlation between him surrounding himself with his family and receiving comfort and feeling happy. Another instance of Victor’s mood being uplifted when noticing the beauty in nature is when Clerval accompanies Victor on his travels. He uses nature to note how beautiful the scenes around Europe are, and recounts how “the appearance of the city had yet in itself sufficient beauty ... the streets are almost magnificent; and the lovely Isis, which flows beside it through meadows of exquisite verdure, is spread forth into a placid expanse of waters, which reflects its majestic assemblage of towers, and spires, and domes, embosomed among aged trees” (Shelley 120). After Victor’s mind turns rampant with detrimental ponderings from isolating himself again to make another creature, he reunites with his childhood best friend and travels through Europe together and feels happier and recognizes more beauty in the world. This helps prove how whenever Victor is with his friends and family, his mindset becomes healthier and more positive, and he sees the world through a better lens, recognizing the beauty in nature. Therefore, Victor’s recognition of the beauty in the nature surrounding him reveals the positive effects of amity in his mood and perspectives.

Similarly, Frankenstein’s ignorance of the beauty of nature conveys how he has been negatively affected by his isolation, as observed through his demeanor and happiness. During the

two years when Frankenstein obsessively perfected his original creation, he had never taken a break to note the beauty in the nature around him. However, after Clerval nurses him back into good health after falling severely ill, Victor reflects upon his experiences in isolation, recalling that “the same feelings which made me neglect the scenes around me caused me also to forget those friends who were so many miles absent, and whom I had not seen for so long a time” (Shelley 36), and how his eyes “were insensible to the charms of nature” (Shelley 36). He vividly describes how his unhealthy obsession, work ethic, and laser-like focus, in complete isolation led him to the point where he was so lost in his passion that he could no longer recognize the beauty of nature. However, when being nursed by his friend, he later notes how the “divine spring; and the season contributed greatly to my convalescence” (Shelley 42). His different views on nature illustrate his shifts in mental health because even though he has isolated himself working on his project for two years and has therefore experienced two springs, he only recognizes the beauty of spring when being treated by Clerval. The contrast between Victor not observing the charms of nature and later admiring its beauty parallel the disparity between Victor’s isolation and interactions with his friend, emphasizing his stark contrast in mood from feeling miserable to the point of not being able to observe any beauty in the world around him, to him feeling comforted with the presence of his friend and by nature around him. Hence, Frankenstein’s perceptions of nature serve as an essential metaphor for communicating Frankenstein’s struggles in solitude and his spirit uplifting when surrounded by loved ones.

Through Shelley’s descriptions of how Frankenstein perceives the nature around him, she indirectly portrays the contrasting effects of isolation and companionship on him with indicative features of mood and mental health. While Frankenstein’s tale of eventually succumbing to his obsession and spiraling down a path of vengeance and depression is unfortunate, readers can

learn from Frankenstein's mistakes. Themes of isolation, depression, and self-destruction in Frankenstein still prove relevant in society today, especially as the world recovers from the lasting effects of the global pandemic, along with the rise of the digital age. However, societies can learn how to better deal with these feelings and themes by recognizing the importance of caring for one's mental health and mood and that all problems have solutions. As artist Henri Matisse once said, "there are always flowers to those who want to see them."

Pre-AP English 10
Frankenstein Literary Analysis Essay

Name: Saanvi
Date: 1/13/23 Period: 1234567

Literary Analysis Rubric Common Core State Standards, Grades 9-10					
	Exceptional	Skilled	Proficient	Developing	Beginning
I D E A S	Concise and sophisticated thesis statement makes an effective claim, addresses the demands of the prompt, AND argues a significant insight that goes beyond in-class discussions.	Concise thesis statement makes an effective claim; addresses the demands of the prompt.	Thesis statement is clear, makes an argument, and addresses the prompt; however, it may be simple or broad.	Some lack of clarity in the thesis; makes an argument that addresses the prompt, but awkwardly or unclearly.	The intended thesis: is not defensible, restates the prompt, provides a summary, OR does not respond to the prompt.
	Thoughtful topic sentences enhance the argument outlined in the thesis.	Clear, concise topic sentence(s) tie back to the thesis.	Main point(s) of the body paragraphs can be determined easily through topic sentence(s).	Main point(s) of the body paragraph(s) can be determined with some difficulty through topic sentence(s).	Main point(s) of the body paragraph(s) are not stated in topic sentences.
	Carefully selected evidence is integrated in such a way that it enhances and supports the argument clearly and fully.	Accurate and relevant evidence is integrated and supports the argument clearly and fully.	Evidence supports the argument; an attempt has been made to integrate evidence but it may not be grammatically correct or appropriate.	Some evidence is present, but evidence presented is not integrated, minimal, not completely accurate, and/or relevant to argument.	Little to no evidence presented; or evidence presented is seriously inaccurate or irrelevant.
	Provides insightful, well-developed analysis that thoughtfully and consistently explains the relationship between the evidence, thesis, and work as a whole.	Provides well-developed analysis that consistently explains the relationship between the evidence and the thesis.	Provides analysis that explains the relationship between evidence and the thesis; however, commentary may be limited (e.g. stops short).	Provides analysis; however, it repeats, over simplifies, or misinterprets the cited information or evidence.	Provides little or no analysis.

	Exceptional	Skilled	Proficient	Developing	Beginning
C R A F T	Uses an organizational structure that enhances the development of ideas. Uses transitions effectively to clarify ideas and create cohesion.	Uses an effective organizational structure and follows a logical progression of ideas. Uses appropriate and varied transitions.	Uses an adequate organizational structure that contains a logical progression of ideas. Uses some varied transitions.	Uses an inconsistent or flawed organizational structure. Uses weak, repetitive, or insufficient transitions.	Does not use an obvious organizational structure. Uses no transitions.
	Uses advanced language and sentence structures that enhance writing. Maintains a professional, academic, and objective tone.	Uses precise language and variety of sentence structures. Maintains an academic and objective tone with few lapses.	Uses some precise language and variety of sentence structures. Generally maintains an academic voice and objective tone.	Uses vague or inappropriate language and flawed or simplistic sentence structures. Lacks an academic voice and objective tone.	Uses inappropriate language and only simple sentences. Voice and tone are inappropriate.
	Has few to no errors in Standard English usage.	Has several minor errors in Standard English usage.	Is generally error free.	Contains errors in Standard English usage that distract from meaning.	Contains multiple errors in Standard English that interfere with meaning.

	Proficient (5 points)	Developing (3 points)	Beginning (1 point)
S T Y L E	☒ Paper is properly formatted in MLA style, including: heading, spacing, indents, consistent size, and font. ☒ In-text citations are in proper MLA Format	Significant/consistent errors with one of the following: ☐ MLA Style ☐ In-text citations	Significant/consistent errors with two or more of the following: ☐ MLA Style ☐ In-text citations

Feedback:

Great essay, Saanvi! Creative connection of literary isolation to Covid lockdowns. Well-integrated quotes + analysis to support thesis. Effective connections. Conclusion links back to pandemic + Matisse quote is a strong close! Well done!
- Mrs B

TOTAL 93 / 95